late 19th century. By the 1890s, one could cover a distance of 400 miles in the same time it took to travel 20 miles a century earlier. Transport costs per ton per mile had fallen by nearly 90 per cent.[89] Internal and international migration surged in the late 19th century alongside the wave of globalisation (and intense famines). The Census of India in 1901 revealed that over 2 per cent of the population was composed of inter-provincial migrants, not too far off from the number for inter-county migration in Britain eighty years earlier, by when Britain was already industrialized.[90] Similarly, India was also a part of the 'Age of Mass Migration' that is otherwise used to characterize the trans-Atlantic migrations from Europe during 1870–1914. Between 1834 and 1937, 30 million people emigrated from India, mainly towards Burma, Malaysia and Sri Lanka, of which nearly 24 million returned.[91] In terms of gross emigration flows, it was similar in magnitude to the trans-Atlantic migration wave, but in net terms, it was different as a large part of the migration was circulatory in nature, though it was similar to the experience of southern Europe. The two world wars in the early 20th century also drew a couple of million Indians to the battlefronts as circulating labour. The circulation that used to take place in India's north-west subsided for the first time in two millennia due to geopolitical reasons, but was replaced by circulatory labour moving towards the plantations in the north-eastern frontier, often assisted by immigration from Nepal. As historians Claude Markovits, Jacques Pouchepadass and Sanjay Subrahmanyam have pointed out, 'circulation has to be treated as a fairly general framework within which to look at Indian society and the transformations it underwent in the modern period, that is at least from the 18th century, if not from an even earlier period'.[92] It is a theme that is laid out in greater detail in the next chapter.

The Landscape of Contemporary Migration

Ancient, medieval and modern-day migrations of different faiths, castes and communities have led to the stunning diversity observed in India and the world, one that continues to be reshaped every day with the arrival of each